

assigned some responsibility and authority to the wife. If the wife in the home can manage finances better than the husband, then she ought to be the bookkeeper. In fact, wives are the bookkeepers in over 80 percent of the homes. And there is nothing wrong with this. We must put aside once and for all this nonsense that somehow the authority in the home is undermined when the wife handles the books.

But this does not mean that when finances are in a mess the husband leaves it to his wife to bail them out. They must both sit down, divide the responsibilities for the home finances, and decide who can best handle what. As far as contacting the creditors and working out a plan to pay, that is obviously the responsibility of the husband.

But deciding how the money should be divided into the various expense categories is a job for both husband *and* wife. They should create a compatible, cooperative plan, not one based on one individual's whims.

PROBLEMS TO WATCH FOR

● BOOKKEEPING ERRORS

It is impossible to have a home budget without balancing your checkbook. If you cannot balance your records, ask your bank account manager for his or her help. Here are some things that you should do to help keep a good checkbook:

(1) Use a ledger-type checkbook (as opposed to a stub type).

(2) Before you tear out the first check, write in every check number.

(3) Before you tear out a check, record the information in the ledger.

(4) One spouse should keep the ledger and the checkbook so that only one person is actually making entries.

(5) Balance the ledger every month without exception.

● HIDDEN DEBTS

Hidden debts usually include bills that do not come due on a monthly basis. Your budget must provide for these. If it